

STATS 506 - Final Project Proposal

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1 Research Question and Analysis Plan

Public confidence in institutions evolves over time and is influenced by major national events and politics. The COVID-19 pandemic was the most recent event that altered everyday life, including social, economic, and political environments, and potentially changed Americans' trust in their government's institutions. This project investigates how Americans' confidence in major government programs and institutions (i.e., the military, media, Congress, the Supreme Court, and more) has changed from pre-pandemic (2015-2019) to post-pandemic periods (May 2023-2024) ¹. Using data from the General Social Survey (GSS), this study will examine whether these patterns differ across demographic groups such as race and sex. Additionally, if time allows, this analysis will explore whether confidence patterns vary depending on which major political party was in office during the survey period.

This project will use publicly available data from the General Social Survey (GSS), conducted by the National Opinion Research Center, which is associated with the University of Chicago. The GSS includes data from 1972 to 2024 and contains a standard set of demographic, behavioral, and attitudinal questions, plus any topics of special interest. There are various questions that ask about the respondents confidence in government organizations and institutions, and these answers can be linked to the respondents sex or race for additional analysis.

The analysis will begin with the years included in the first paragraph, but may eventually add more to the pre-pandemic period, as to address the inquiry into political party and confidence. To begin, EDA will be done with descriptive statistics and visualizations summarizing the confidence across time and across the different institutions. Statistical comparisons of confidence before versus after the pandemic will be assessed using hypothesis testing and the resulting t-test summaries. To assess the roles of demographic factors (race and sex) and political party in office, regression modeling will be used, specifically linear regression models will be applied to the continuous measures, and logistic regression will be used for categorical confidence outcomes (I tried to download the data set and load into R, but it was killing my computer so I stopped, so I don't know how the respondents can answer the questions on confidence). Interaction terms will be included in these models to test whether changes in confidence differ across demographic groups and or vary depending on the party in office.

¹The federal COVID-19 PHE declaration ended on May 11, 2023.